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ENGL 225 Shakespeare: Beyond Tragedy

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Hal the Princely Hypocrite: Social Expectations and Insincerity

Prince Hal returns to the stage and to England in Act 2 Scene 2 of Shakespeare's *King Henry, Part 2*. By the end of Part 1, Hal has redeemed his "lost opinion" by saving his father King Henry's life (*IH4*, 5.4.47), killed rebellious Hotspur and "exchange[d] his glorious deeds for [Hal's] indignities" (*IH4*, 3.2.46), and set off to stifle a Welsh rebellion. Now, he has returned to England—and to his friend Ned Poins:

POINS. How ill it follows, after you have laboured so hard, you should talk so idly. Tell me, how many good young princes would do so, their fathers being so sick as yours at this time is?

PRINCE HENRY. Shall I tell thee one thing, Poins?

POINS. Yes, faith, and let it be an excellent good thing.

PRINCE HENRY. It shall serve among wits of no higher breeding than thine.

POINS. Go to, I stand the push of your one thing that you will tell.

PRINCE HENRY. Marry, I tell thee it is not meet that I should be sad now my father is sick; albeit I could tell to thee, as to one it pleases me, for fault of a better, to call my friend, I could be sad, and sad indeed too.

POINS. Very hardly, upon such a subject.

PRINCE HENRY. By this hand, thou thinkest me as far in the devil's book as thou and Falstaff, for obduracy and persistency. Let the end try the man. But I tell thee, my heart bleeds inwardly that my father is so sick; and keeping such vile company as thou art hath, in reason, taken from me all ostentation of sorrow.

POINS. The reason?

PRINCE HENRY. What wouldst thou think of me if I should weep?

POINS. I would think thee a most princely hypocrite.

PRINCE HENRY. It would be every man's thought, and thou art a blessed fellow to think as every man thinks. Never a man's thought in the world keeps the roadway better than thine. Every man would think me a hypocrite indeed. And what accites your most worshipful thought to think so?

POINS. Why, because you have been so lewd, and so much engrafted to Falstaff.

PRINCE HENRY. And to thee.

POINS. By this light, I am well spoke on; I can hear it with mine own ears. The worst that they can say of me is that I am a second brother, and that I am a proper fellow of my hands, and those two things I confess I cannot help. (2.2.27-64).

Ned's use of *thee* in line 51 is immediately surprising, as it is his only use of it to Hal in the two plays. The use of the informal *thee* can denote superiority, disdain, or intimacy, depending on the context (Womack 1). In all of his other interactions, Ned seeks to entertain Hal and himself through mocking others. Is it finally Hal's turn to be mocked? Although Ned could be genuinely critical of Hal's hypocrisy, it is more likely that he is trying to tease Hal, but both tones convey to Hal that he cannot be sincere around his friends.

Immediately before this excerpt, Hal had lamented how embarrassing it was for a man of his stature to be so familiar with someone like Ned: "What a disgrace is it to me to remember thy name! Or to know thy face tomorrow!" (2.2.12-14). Hal's friendship with Ned is complicated, since, although Ned and Hal are bad influences on each other, they are both nobility, unlike Falstaff and the tavern staff. Being friends with Ned is not as intrinsically bad as Hal described, although Ned is on the less desirable end of nobility as a second son and a fighter (2.2.62-64). Hal's dramatic lamentation, thus, would naturally offend or amuse Ned. In either case, Ned tries to counter by presenting Hal's flaws.

As Hal begins his first confession to anyone other than his father that he is not as bad as he acts, Ned either pretends to be or genuinely is oblivious to Hal's sincerity. Ned pedantically emphasizes Hal's "one thing that [he] will tell" (2.2.35-36), which slows down the conversation, and then rejects the concept of Hal's sadness. Under the hypothesis that Ned genuinely considers Hal to be two-faced, does not let Hal explain himself, but rather forces Hal to sit with the fact that he is lying to everyone. However, this seems out of character for Ned, who, unlike Falstaff, always treats Hal as a close friend, accomplice, or his superior. It is more likely that Ned, who

often sees Hal and Falstaff bicker, is misreading the room. This is similar to, for example, a woman sharing concerns about her boyfriend, but her friends jokingly insist that she should dump him, instead of genuinely hearing the concerns and suggesting solutions. Although the joking tone comes from good intentions, it ends up dismissing the original topic.

Regardless of whether Ned is bitter or teasing, he is neither listening to nor accepting what Hal is saying. In response to being called a hypocrite, Hal retorts, “It would be every man’s thought, and thou art a blessed fellow to think as every man thinks” (2.2.52). This line bitterly echoes another scene in which Hal was ignored: his conversation with his father the King. In *Henry VI Part 1*, King Henry, in a long tirade against Hal’s truancy and delinquency, snaps, “...the soul of every man / Prophetically do forethink thy fall” (3.2.37-38). Although neither King Henry nor Ned allow Hal to properly explain himself, King Henry dominates his conversation and ignores Hal’s interjections (116 lines of verse to Hal’s 45 within *IH4* 3.2.1-161), while Ned allows Hal to ramble before undercutting it with short quips (around 20 lines of prose to Hal’s 42 within 2.2.1-64). Even though these conversations are so distinct, they carry the common message that Hal’s friends and family have expectations for him that they refuse to change at his behest. Even now, with Hal redeemed in King Henry’s eyes, King Henry is quick to call Hal power-hungry (4.3.222).

A common critique of Hal is that he is manipulative for his own means. His actions and words oppose each other, and he lies for his own future benefit. However, he has proven that he is neither malicious nor anxious to rule (cf. “O God, they did me too much injury / That ever said I hearkened for your death” *IH4*, 5.4.50-51), despite what Ned and King Henry insist. The only way for him to then redeem himself, when no one close to him believes him, is to completely separate from his old life. This helps explain why he waits until his father is dead and then

banishes Falstaff: the largest barriers between Hal and acting sincerely are his friends and family. Even though Hal continues to use wordplay and have ulterior motives in *Henry V*, no one is stopping him from showing his sincere desire to help his kingdom.

Ned, who has little importance of his own, represents in this scene the amount of pressure Hal has been under to stay as he is, despite others' critiques. Further analysis of this conversation could discuss how Ned is a foil of Hal's brother John of Lancaster. Neither are firstborn sons, but both trick their enemies and are skilled fighters. Unfortunately, Ned's disappearance prevents this foil relationship from developing further. Additionally, one could discuss how gender and toxic masculinity play into the feeling rules placed upon Hal, especially with how gender is held strictly by King Henry and loosely by Falstaff. Despite having close friends who seem to be accepting of a lot of social faux pas, Hal has no one that will let him be himself.

Works Cited

Womack, Mark. "*Thou and You* in Shakespeare." *Dr. Mark Womack*,
<https://drmarkwomack.com/pdfs/thou-and-you.pdf>. Accessed 5 March 2026.